

Conflicts of Interest

■ N. Srinivasan wears several hats: he is BCCI secretary and IPL governing council member. He also owns the Chennai Super Kings (CSK) franchise through his company India Cements. National selection chief K. Srikkanth is a brand ambassador for CSK.

■ The IPL governing council member also issued a \$5-million compensation to the two Indian teams due to play in the cancelled 2008 IPL Champions League: Rajasthan Royals and CSK.

■ The most notable team missing from the BCCI's newly-launched Corporate Cup is Chemplast, bitter rivals of India Cements in the Chennai club league.



chief of Indian selectors who judges players and decides on annual contracts. (In a curious coincidence of 37 BCCI contracts for 2008-09, eight went to CSK players, more than any other IPL team. Of those eight, five CSK men were on the list of 14 given the Rs 15 lakh a year contracts to fringe players).

Wearing his IPL governing council member hat, Srinivasan has disbursed a \$5-million compensation to the two teams due to play in the now-cancelled 2008 IPL Champions League: winners Rajasthan Royals, runners-up CSK.

In his BCCI secretary hat, the Board launched a lucrative Corporate Trophy for firms with a long tradition for supporting cricket, employing players and competing in club events. The most prominent name missing

from the list of contestants is that of Chennai-based Chemplast, which have fielded a club team for 50 years and employed 30 former Test cricketers. Coincidence again, Chemplast happen to be bitter rivals of India Cements in the Tamil Nadu Cricket Association League.

Not so long ago, Modi and Srinivasan fought together to unseat Jagmohan Dalmiya. Modi himself is hardly lily-white. Srinivasan's letter to IMG terminating services was first emailed to a giant mailing list of IPL franchises, their employees and other concerned parties. The same letter then, mysteriously, was also soon found to be 'in the possession of' every major newspaper and television channel across the country.

Then, in an act of synchronised timing that would have Swiss watchmakers burning up in envy, letters of support for IMG came pouring out of the franchise offices. Ask a franchise official about the letters and his answer is wry: "Who could refuse?"

Franchises admit that in the first year the IMG's expertise was needed to put up such a large, logistically-complicated exercise in India and then transport the event to South Africa.

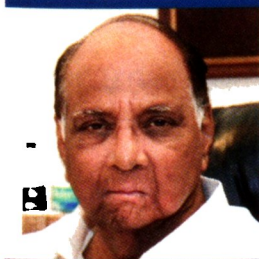
"IMG did bring value to organising the league," says a franchise official, "but two years on, it can be easily replaced." For the IPL, IMG bring between 30 and 40 of their staff from England some, BCCI officials say, more "bullish" than the others. "Some of their staff was very rude to state association officials—and that puts people off." Now the put-offs want payback.

Constituted as a sub-committee of the BCCI, the IPL ran its course in the first year playing under rules that changed so often they seemed to be written in invisible ink. Once the numbers were crunched, state associations sat up. Under the 10 per cent rule, IMG had walked away with Rs 42.92 crore and the hosting associations had only received Rs 4 lakh each for use of their venue.

When IMG disputed the revised figure of Rs 33 crore and indicated that there would be no further negotiations on the subject, the decision to terminate services was taken on August 13 at the working committee.

The entry of former BCCI president and current remote control Sharad Pawar into this debate in support of IMG/Modi has sent the first hint to the folks in the Board that the power equations may not be what they believed them to be. Under the BCCI rules, the next president of the Board must come from the South Zone, which should logically make it Srinivasan's turn.

The IMG issue, many predict, will be sorted out smoothly inside three weeks. Modi vs Srinivasan will however continue to simmer. It's a contest between the well-entrenched and the well-oiled. Game on.



“Not only this will lead to a prolonged legal battle but it will also show us in bad light in public.”

SHARAD PAWAR
FORMER PRESIDENT, BCCI